

« Fielding is a critical aspect that requires constant attention. In any team, the goal is always to seek continuous improvement »

T. DILIP

Ayan Acharya

ayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

It's been over two months since India's T20 World Cup victory in the Caribbean, and the team now has a new support staff, led by head coach Gautam Gambhir. However, a familiar face remains in the dressing room — fielding coach T. Dilip, who continues in his role from the previous regime.

In this chat, Dilip talks about that memorable World Cup final, modern fielding, coaching an elite bunch, and what makes Ravindra Jadeja such a gun fielder.

The crosswind was a big factor at all venues in the Caribbean, including the final. How did the boys train for it? Were there any specific instructions given to the boundary riders?

We recognised early on that adapting to these conditions would be key to maintaining our fielding standards. Boundary riders were particularly focused on, as they are most affected by the crosswind. We emphasised the importance of tracking the ball and adjusting their positions based on the wind's influence.

This involved drills where they had to take high catches using "variable-weight balls." We also stressed the importance of effective communication between the boundary riders and infielders.

Suryakumar Yadav's catch has been touted as one of the best under pressure, if not the best. If you could describe your reaction, as well as the dressing room's response, as David Miller played that shot.

I wasn't in the dressing room when SKY took that phenomenal catch — I was on the boundary, closely observing the game. The moment Miller played that shot, my heart skipped a beat as the ball went up in the air. Watching SKY position himself perfectly and execute the catch under immense pressure was an amazing feeling. My immediate reaction was pure elation, knowing that this catch could be a game-changer for us.

Rohit Sharma usually fields inside the circle, but that day in the final, as Hardik came on to bowl the 20th over, we saw him stationed at long on. Was there a particular reason for that, or was it just a gut call?

One of the reasons Rohit is such a valuable asset to our fielding unit is his versatility. He's comfortable fielding anywhere on the ground, whether it's inside the circle or on the boundary. We needed a fielder with experience, someone who could stay composed under pressure. In addition, it was a way of saving time.

Because in T20 cricket every second counts as there is a specific time limit to finish the overs.

Given the squad was just coming out of the IPL, where the outfields were generally pretty lush and green, how different was it training the guys for fielding on the grounds, especially in the USA? Is there a distinct change in methods of practice?

The outfields in the USA can vary significantly, with the grounds having softer, sand-based surfaces. This required us to adapt our training methods to ensure the players were aware of the challenges. One of the key adjustments was maintaining our attacking approach on the outfield but also being aware of the consequences of diving. We incorporated more drills that simulated taking good routes to the ball.

Batsmen often have to change mindsets when they switch formats. Does it apply to fielding as well?

In all formats, the fundamental skills of fielding remain the same, but the application and intensity vary. In T20 cricket, the pace of the game is incredibly fast, and fielding becomes an intense, high-energy activity.